

The book's most compelling sections examine the structures that shape artistic recognition in Hindustani music. Ramanan looks at how patronage, institutional dynamics and the star-driven festival circuit influence musicians' careers. Kashalkar's modest public visibility, despite performances at respected platforms, becomes a lens through which she examines entrenched hierarchies and challenges assumptions about visibility, acclaim and value.

Equally affecting are the chapters that describe her own attempts to learn his intricate style. Her candid accounts of struggle, bewilderment and occasional triumph bring emotional depth to the narrative and reveal the profound interiority of a musician who has consistently chosen substance over spectacle.

The Secret Master is a notable contribution to contemporary writing on Indian classical music. It documents an important yet understated figure, interrogates the politics of recognition and affirms the vitality of tradition. Ramanan's affectionate writing makes for an essential read. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

IT WAS DIFFICULT FOR MANY PRACTIONERS TO BREAK SOCIAL AND MUSICAL STEREOTYPES. MANY SHIFTED TO TEACHING

easier, despite his lineage. Even the instrumentalists Kala Ramnath and Yogesh Samsi, are relative outliers in their fields.

The first-person stories detail the risks in a life of music. It is difficult to break stereotypes—both musical and social. Many expert Hindustani musicians accept defeat, choosing the modest life of teachers. Paradoxically, as the author suggests, it is these musician-teachers who have preserved the traditions' lifeblood. ■

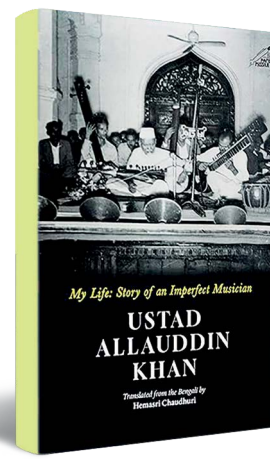
—Partho Datta

BOOKS ▼

A **Maestro** Remembers

USTAD ALLAUDDIN KHAN's autobiography offers an intimate insight into Indian classical music of the early 20th century

In 1952, the legendary musician Baba Allauddin Khan accepted a professorial post at Visva Bharati, Santiniketan. There, over two sittings, he recounted to Subhamoy Ghosh some episodes from his life. Transcriptions of these narrations were clubbed with additional material, including an introduction by sitar exponent Pandit Ravi Shankar, and published under the title *Āmār Kathā* (My Story). (I am not sure where the 'Story of an Imperfect Musician' in the English title derives from.)



MY LIFE Story of an Imperfect Musician
By Ustad Allauddin Khan, translated from the Bengali by Hemasri Chaudhuri
NIYOGI BOOKS
₹499; 120 pages

Baba traces his lineage to the Robin Hood–like brigand Dinanath Dev Sharma who adopted Islam to evade arrest. Young Allauddin was so obsessed with music that he chose to run away from home and seek tutelage in Calcutta. Dhrupad exponent Gopalchandra Chakraborty, known as Nulo or Lulu Gopal, taught him the basics of music. His untimely death led Allauddin to other preceptors, including sarod exponent Ahmed Ali and then the legendary Ujir (Wazir) Khan of Rampur, to gain whose tutelage Allauddin turned to means as desperate as throwing himself in the path of the Rampur Nawab's cavalcade to obtain a recommendation. The chapter ends with him becoming the court musician of Maihar State. The second chapter concerns Baba's sojourns abroad. Ravi Shankar's introduction offers a fascinating glimpse into life and tutelage at Maihar, replete with anecdotes about Baba's temper, kindness, devotion to music and simplicity.

Translating Baba's staccato, highly idiomatic, at times even disjointed narration style, poses a challenge. Chaudhuri does a competent job, commendable for someone still a school student. Occasional lapses do occur. For instance, Lulu Goswami's [*sic* Gopal] mandate of 12 years' *sur sādhanā* (dedicated study) is rendered as 'For twelve years you will have to learn to hold a tune' (p. 32). Overall, the book offers valuable insights into what Indian music used to be. ■

—Abhik Majumdar